superpower, they are more likely to bandwagon with the superpower or follow a hedging strategy. In a multipolar structure, secondary states are also more likely to hedge because of uncertainty as to which of the major powers is the most likely threat and which the most likely ally or allies. In a bipolar system, on the other hand, hedging would be less common as "both superpowers engage in balancing with each other, whereas secondary powers experience difficulty in maintaining strategic ambiguity or neutrality and are compelled to engage in either balancing or bandwagoning."[23] If we are on the threshold of returning to a new bipolar world structure, with the United States and China as the two superpowers,[24] India would by definition have to be regarded as a secondary power, although a very strong one, and we should thus expect India to either balance against or bandwagon with China.

Within the classical realist school, it is acknowledged that balancing is a regional process rather than a global process and that the alignment decisions of regional powers are determined by the shifting balance of power in their immediate vicinity and not in the international system at large.[25] Hence, if we accept geographic proximity as an important variable in the analysis of power, we should expect India to balance the largest power in its vicinity, meaning China, and align with the other great power in the international system, which is the United States.[26] Moreover, while weaker states tend to bandwagon, we should expect stronger states to balance their neighbours.[27] India is certainly a strong state, with a higher likelihood of balancing China than bandwagoning with China.

To explore whether India is balancing China, we need to define balancing. There is, however, no single standardised definition.[28] Waltz divided balancing into two categories, internal and external. He defined internal balancing as efforts to increase economic capability, to increase military